SkintKit

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The used camera & lens checklist

Second-hand is the skint way into proper photography. These are the checks Lewis, a working wedding and events photographer, runs before buying used kit. Tick them off on your phone or hit print.

1. ☐ **Shutter count**
   Ask for it before anything else. It's the camera's mileage. A seller who won't say is a red flag.
2. ☐ **Sensor**
   Take a photo of a white wall or sky at f/16. Dark spots that stay put are dust or damage.
3. ☐ **Screen and buttons**
   Press every button, turn every dial, open every door. Check the screen for dead pixels and scratches.
4. ☐ **Battery and charger**
   Make sure both are included and the battery holds a charge. Budget for a spare anyway.
5. ☐ **Card slot and ports**
   Put a card in, format it, shoot and play back. Check the mic, HDMI and USB ports if you shoot video.
6. ☐ **Lens glass**
   Shine a phone torch through the lens. Look for haze, fungus (spidery threads) and scratches. A little dust is normal.
7. ☐ **Focus**
   Autofocus on something close and something far. Manual lenses: the focus ring should turn smoothly with no grinding.

8. ☐ **Aperture**
   On older lenses, flick the aperture lever and watch the blades snap shut. Oily or sticky blades are a no.
9. ☐ **Mount**
   Check the lens fits your camera, or that an adapter exists. Look for wear or cracks on the metal mount.
10. ☐ **Test shots**
    Take a few photos and look at them full size on your phone or laptop before you pay.
11. ☐ **Seller**
    Use a dealer or a seller with solid feedback. Avoid bank transfers to strangers; use a payment method with buyer protection.
12. ☐ **Warranty and returns**
    Dealers usually give a warranty and a return window. That's worth paying a bit more for on a body or an expensive lens.

Rather skip the risk?

A dealer does most of these checks for you and adds a warranty.

Not sure what to buy?